

WADERS, GULLS, AND AUKS

Largely birds of coastal areas, waders are diverse in form and habit. Many are adapted for feeding in mud and water, with long legs and a probing bill.

The birds collectively known as waders, or Charadriiformes, fall into three main groups. Of these, two groups are made up of shorebirds. Plovers and allied species are mostly short-legged, short-billed birds that feed on small invertebrates found close to the surface of the ground. Some birds in this group, such as lapwings, favour drier habitats inland. Other species in the plover group are more adapted to wetland. Stilts and avocets sweep shallow water with their needle-like bill, while oystercatchers use their long stout bill for opening mollusc shells. In the group consisting

of sandpipers, snipe, and allies, the birds use their long bill to probe deep mud. Some of their relatives, such as shanks and curlews, have long legs, too, and so can wade into deeper water to feed.

OCEANIC BIRDS

The final group in this order is made up of gulls, terns, skuas, and auks – web-footed birds that are the most ocean-going of the order. They may spend much of their lives at sea and some travel immense distances on migration. Gulls are opportunistic predators that are also seen foraging far inland. Auks, distributed around the Arctic, are specialized for diving for ocean-swimming prey. Their black and white coloration gives them a superficial resemblance to penguins, but they are not close relatives.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	CHARADRIIFORMES
FAMILIES	19
SPECIES	383

DEBATE

ORIGIN OF A GULL

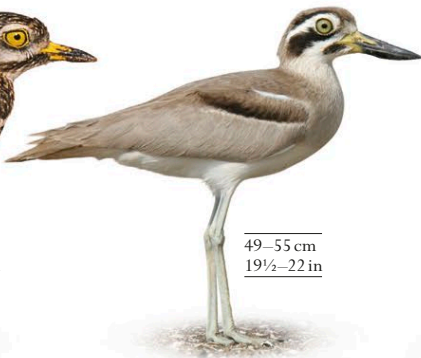
New species appear when populations diverge too much to interbreed with others. In this way it was thought that European herring gulls diverged from Asian ancestors that spread eastwards to encircle the Arctic. Recent evidence suggests herring gulls descended from gulls isolated in the North Atlantic.



40–44 cm
16–17½ in

EURASIAN STONE CURLEW
Burhinus oedicnemus
F: Burhinidae

Named after their shrill curlew-like calls, the mostly nocturnal stone curlews are related to plovers. This widespread Eurasian species occurs in dry mudflats inland.



49–55 cm
19½–22 in

GREAT STONE CURLEW
Esacus recurvirostris
F: Burhinidae

Large *Esacus* stone curlews have a chisel-like bill for hunting prey, such as crabs, near water. This is a S. Asian species.



34–41 cm
13½–16 in

SNOWY SHEATHBILL
Chionis albus
F: Chionidae

This is one of two white sheathbills, Antarctic cousins of plovers, which scavenge and consume carrion and the food and young of other birds.



20–22 cm
8–9 in

MAGELLANIC PLOVER
Pluvianellus socialis
F: Chionidae

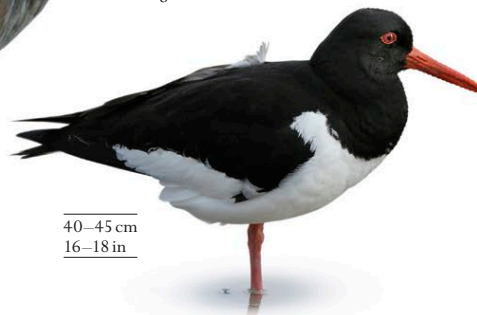
This unusual S. American wader – the only one to regurgitate food for chicks – is more closely related to sheathbills than other plovers.



42–47 cm
16½–18½ in

AMERICAN BLACK OYSTERCATCHER
Haematopus bachmani
F: Haematopodidae

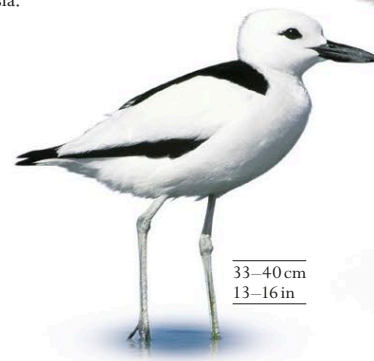
Black oystercatchers generally have more restricted ranges than pied (having two or more colours) species. This species is confined to the west coast of N. America.



40–45 cm
16–18 in

EURASIAN OYSTERCATCHER
Haematopus ostralegus
F: Haematopodidae

The most widespread oystercatcher, this pied species breeds in N. Eurasia. Like others, it uses its long bill to open bivalve molluscs.



33–40 cm
13–16 in

CRAB PLOVER
Dromas ardeola
F: Dromadidae

The crab plover may be more closely related to gulls than to true plovers. Found around Indian Ocean coastlines, it uses its stout bill for eating crabs.